

Wales Green Party **Plaid Werdd Cymru**



2nd vote Green

to defend public services and build a low
carbon economy

National Assembly for Wales
Election Manifesto 2011

Contents:

i. Our Vision

ii. Key Aims

1. Economy

- a. A Strong Welsh Economy
- b. Protecting vital services
- c. Raising additional revenue
- d. Local Business
- e. Work and Jobs

2. Environment

- a. Climate Change
- b. Energy
- c. Waste
- d. Food and Farming
- e. Wildlife, open spaces and landscape
- f. Taking Animal Protection Seriously

3. Services

- a. Housing
- b. Education
- c. Welsh Language
- d. Health
- e. Local Services
- f. Transport
- g. Strong Communities
- h. Citizens
- i. Promoting equality, celebrating diversity

Our vision for Wales

The Green Party plans to put Wales back to satisfying and meaningful work. What we've seen over the past year is an economy in turmoil, slashing jobs and eating into pensions and savings. Our 'Green New Deal' offers a radical new approach to bringing job security, economic stability and environmental sustainability.

Other parties make feeble promises to kick-start a Green economy, but maintain 'business as usual' with the very same global companies that helped to bring about the economic and environmental crises. Our Green New Deal would turn this on its head, supporting local business, creating 50,000 sustainable jobs, and forming the core of our transformation of Wales to a fairer, more prosperous economy.

Fairness must be central to this transition. Research has shown that more equal societies do better, and that equality is the main route to a better society for everyone, rich and poor. Inequality and greed caused the financial and environmental crises we are living through today and lie at the root of many social problems. Only the Greens are serious about ending rampant inequality, deregulation and laissez-faire economics. Greens have understood the lessons of the financial crisis, and know what to do about it.

The Green Party also understands that we need a one-planet economy. This means that we should only use the resources available to us, ensuring a secure and prosperous future for our children. Politicians have failed to control the over-use of resources, systematically consuming more than the planet will be able to replenish during our lifetime. These unsustainable policies look set to cause huge problems for future generations as key resources run out and the effects of climate change set in.

Our key aims:

- ✓ **Protecting vital public services** - Recession or not our schools, hospitals and public transport come first, we shouldn't have to pay for the bankers' mistakes.
- ✓ **Create 50,000 jobs in the low carbon economy**, tackling climate change and fuel poverty by insulating our homes, developing renewable energy and public transport.
- ✓ **Supporting our local businesses** - Local businesses need to be favoured over multi-nationals and big businesses.
- ✓ **Safe clean energy, not nuclear** - We can get all of our energy from clean renewable sources, we do not need dangerous nuclear power.
- ✓ **Fairer funding for schools** - Work to ensure that money allocated for schools is actually passed on by local authorities, increasing the proportion from the current 75% to 90%.
- ✓ **Localise the food chain**, including assistance for small farms, farmers' markets, farm box schemes and locally owned co-ops.
- ✓ Follow Scotland's lead in looking to implement **free social care for the elderly**.

Economy

Building a Strong Welsh Economy: Taking the Lead in Wales

The Green Party has plans to put Wales back to satisfying and meaningful work. It's so obvious that business as usual doesn't work. We have to build a sustainable economy and society, otherwise there's no future for anyone.

For years, the National Assembly for Wales has followed an economic strategy of attracting inward investment. The drive towards an increasingly unaccountable global market threatens jobs, workers' skills and the environment. Inward investment is as easily lost as it is hard to win, with production now increasingly being moved to low wage countries.

The Green Party believes we must stop the cap-in-hand mentality towards global investors - moving grant aid away from multinational corporations towards small and medium sized sustainable Welsh businesses.

With the economic crisis bringing spiralling unemployment and poverty, investment is vital. But we must also make important long-term changes: moving towards a zero-carbon economy, away from an obsession with growth for the sake of growth, and towards a more equal society.

Casino capitalism has become more important than making things and providing services. Houses have become speculative investments instead of somewhere to live.

We believe that only the following policies will deliver the equitable, stable and sustainable economy we so badly need:

- Invest in the green economy now. If in certain vital sectors such as energy generation, the private sector is acting too slowly or on an insufficient scale, the Government must take the lead.
- Support innovative new ways of investing in the green economy, by increasing the financial powers of the Assembly.
- Protect basic public services, which are the foundation of an equitable society. Cuts to health and education will hit the poorest and most vulnerable first. We must help the poorest pensioners and children in particular.
- Reverse the Welsh Government's policy of providing only loans to SMEs whilst giving grants to large corporations.

Protecting vital public services

Cutting investment now, as the Tory/Lib-Dem Government intends, could cause spiralling unemployment and low demand and lead to a double-dip recession. The Green Party is in opposition to the cuts.

Instead, we should be asking the people who caused the crisis and those who profit from environmental destruction to pay something back. This would mean taxing the financial sector, polluting industry, aviation and big business. It would also mean cracking down on tax havens and other forms of tax avoidance.

Greens in the Welsh Assembly would oppose cuts handed down from Westminster and work to ensure that Wales has a sustainable economy, financed by those who can pay.

- To protect public services we would work with local government and trade unions to protect jobs and avoid compulsory redundancies.

Raising additional revenue

We will prioritise finding the means to raise additional revenue to protect public services and develop the infrastructure for the low carbon economy:

- We would urgently seek to renegotiate the Barnett formula to ensure it recognises Wales' true needs.
- We will argue for borrowing powers to be given to the Assembly, so that Wales can invest in jobs and infrastructure when they are needed.
- We would seek to set up a non-profit organisation able to issue bonds to fund investment in infrastructure.
- Introduce a network of local community banks, which will provide, among other things, a new source of finance for small businesses.

Small business

Promoting diversity.

We would:

- Refocus financial support towards the needs of local, smaller and medium sized businesses, rather than trying to attract inward investment from large overseas multinationals. In particular we would further reduce rates for small businesses.
- Engage with local businesses to find out what support they require, and ensure those services provide continuity, not constant change. Promote a

restructuring of local supply chains between public and private sectors.
Increasing the inclusion of local companies in public sector tendering.

- Ensure all new retail and residential developments, however large, include spaces for local and small, growing businesses.
- Help small businesses cope with regulation and provide tailored advice on energy efficiency.
- Rural businesses have been particularly hit by fuel cost increases. We would find ways to help small companies cope with increasing fuel prices.
- Promote alternatives to the competitive cash economy - supporting LETS (Local Exchange Trading Systems) systems, co-operatives, community enterprises, development trusts, and credit unions, as means of building up local economies and ensuring that finance is spread more widely amongst our communities.

Work and jobs

Working to live, not living to work.

The loss of jobs that has gone with mismanagement of an unsustainable economic model is a criminal waste of talent and aspiration, and has turned life into a daily struggle for many thousands of people in Wales.

As top bankers continue to pocket your money in the form of unearned bonuses; factories, firms and farms are forced to lay off more and more workers by the day, week and month.

This must end. Our major and immediate priority is the creation of an extra jobs and training places which would address both employment and environmental problems.

It would consist of a package of measures described throughout this manifesto, including workforce training, investment in renewables, public transport, insulation, social housing and waste management. We would also:

- Develop the green jobs strategy of WAG, ensuring it realises its true potential. The Green Party estimates 50,000 jobs could be created in the low carbon economy in Wales.
- Offer Green workforce training, including training courses for jobs in energy conservation and renewable energy, with grant-funded conversion courses for skilled engineers from other industries.
- Enhance and expand the Flying Start Network. Flying start has made a real difference to the lives of some of our poorest children.
- Value and protect carers and volunteers.
- Support moves towards workplace democracy and ensure that workers and former workers control their pension funds.
- Support a greater role for co-operatives.

Our energy policy is not just the best for climate change – it also produces the most jobs:

Number of jobs created per terawatt hour by each energy source:

Wind	918–2400
Coal	370
Gas and oil	250–265
Nuclear	75

Our proposals for insulation and other energy efficiency measures would also create steady employment for thousands of people.

Environment

Climate change

The canary in the mine.

Miners used to take canaries down mines with them to check for poisonous gases. They were an advance warning of impending problems. That's what climate change is today – a threat in itself to our survival as a species and a warning of more general ecological collapse.

The evidence from Copenhagen and Cancun suggests that mainstream governments just haven't grasped the nature and scale of the changes that need to be made, from massive investments in energy saving, to green technologies and infrastructure, to transfers of funds to developing countries. Here in Wales, the Assembly Government has said we can generate all of our electricity from renewable sources, yet recently we failed to meet our targets for renewable generation.

Human-made climate change is an unprecedented threat to our welfare. But only the Green Party understands that this is just one sign of the stress our economies and lifestyles put on the environment.

With this in mind, we would set the Assembly the target of cutting CO2 emissions by 10% per annum on 1990 levels, with the long term aim of cutting emissions by 65% by 2020 and 90% by 2030. The current 3% target within devolved areas is nowhere near sufficient.

Other political parties will have you believe that it's just an isolated problem. But it's not. It's a sign of what's to come unless we get our planetary home in order. Our manifesto therefore tackles climate change and environmental degradation throughout, as a part of a greater systemic problem.

In the current economic climate it is easy for the main parties to appear green as environmentally destructive projects are postponed by financial reasons. We are concerned that when finances improve projects such as the M4 relief road and the International Business Park at Junction 33 could be revived. Greens in the Assembly will continue to provide principled opposition to such projects.

Energy

Reducing demand, securing supply.

We would:

- Ensure there is a coherent monitoring system in place to enable assessment against emission reduction targets.
- Prioritise the new 3 Rs: Remove, Reduce, Replace. First remove demand altogether where possible (e.g. by stopping the carbon intensive activity altogether, or by true zero carbon technology); then reduce demand (e.g. by energy-efficiency measures); then switch to renewables for whatever energy need is left.
- The private sector has not responded to the challenge of renewable energy with sufficient vigour and investment. We would introduce a programme of direct Government investment in wind and other renewable generation, creating jobs in installation and equipment manufacture.
- Require all major development plans and planning applications to show how they will contribute to carbon reduction targets.
- Set building regulations to require excellent energy standards on a points-based system, which will cover embodied energy of building materials, energy used in construction, energy consumption in use, on-site energy generation and use of heat distribution networks.
- Introduce a free home insulation programme for all homes that need it, with priority for pensioners and those living in fuel poverty, aiming to insulate 40,000 homes every year.
- Introduce minimum standards for renewables on new build homes, commercial and public buildings.
- Aim to obtain about half our energy from renewable sources by 2020 and ensure that emissions from power generation are zero by 2030.
- Phase out nuclear power and resolutely oppose any new nuclear power stations. Stop any further investment in new coal-fuelled power stations.
- Encourage renewable heat and combined heat and power by helping councils develop heat distribution networks in suitable urban areas. Work to increase the adoption of biogas from organic sources such as agricultural and sewage waste materials, working with the water companies to build digestion plants.
- Introduce stronger planning policies to support wind, tidal, wave, solar and geothermal energy schemes.

Waste

Reduce, reuse – and only then recycle.

Government must provide the infrastructure to make it easy to do the right thing.

We would:

- Aim to raise recycling levels to 70% by 2015 as a move towards a zero-waste system by 2030. The Government provides the infrastructure, people do the recycling.
- Oppose the incineration of waste, but encourage domestic composting. Encourage the use of sustainable waste treatment such as anaerobic digestion with energy recovery.
- We will use taxation on unnecessary packaging to discourage its use.
- Introduce a German style deposit on bottles, cans etc to encourage reuse of packaging. Reusing packaging localises the supply chain, reducing food miles and creating jobs locally.

Food and farming

Healthy and affordable food and recreation.

We would:

- Localise the food chain, including assistance for small farms, farmers' markets, farm box schemes and locally owned co-ops.
- Maintain a GM-free Wales and oppose attempts by the UK government to weaken our GM free status at an EU level.
- Work to measure and reduce the impact of our meat and dairy consumption, while recognising that traditional rotational grazing has potential for storing carbon in the soil.
- Improve food skills by encouraging schools to involve children in growing, preparing and cooking food.
- Reduce the dominance of supermarket chains through a range of measures, such as:
 - Enforce planning restrictions on new out-of-town developments, and require parking charges for private car parks with exemption for the disabled.
 - Insisting that 50% of retail floor space in all new developments is affordable space for local small businesses.
 - Including clear policies on sustainability to enable planning authorities to give priority to local firms and farms.
 - Prohibiting new private retail parking in large developments, except for that designated for the disabled.

- Providing many more allotments. Most people who want an allotment should be able to get one. Councils should use existing powers to designate new allotments in perpetuity.
- Promote local markets across Wales, bringing farmers and consumers together.
- Support and enhance existing diversification into energy production, farm forestry and small 'value added' business ventures.
- Work with Green MEPs in the European Union to ensure sustainable farming is embedded in the Common Agricultural Policy.
- Ensuring a careful move over to the proposed Glastir scheme, giving every farm an opportunity to benefit and learning from past administrative failings

Wildlife, open spaces and landscape

We must protect our wildlife and landscape and their diversity, both for their own sake and ours. Clean air, water, food and flood regulation all depend on the natural landscape.

Biodiversity is under threat. Human activity means we are losing about 30,000 species per year. We have a historic opportunity not only to halt the degradation of our natural environment, but to begin to roll back two centuries of exploitation.

We would:

- Promote landscape-scale conservation, using reform of planning system to encourage restoration of heath lands, woods, marshland and other important habitats.
- Minimise encroachment onto undeveloped 'greenfield sites' wherever possible by reusing previously developed sites that have fallen into disuse.
- Oppose the watering down of planning regulations, particularly for new roads, runways, incinerators and inappropriate housing developments, and ensure that sustainable development, not just economic development, is at the heart of the planning system.
- Take steps to ensure that development is more evenly distributed across the whole of the country, reducing pressure on housing in the Cardiff region in particular.
- Increase the tranquillity of our urban environments, with less litter, less noise, reduced light pollution and more green spaces. Everyone should live within walking distance of natural green space.
- Enhance protection of our marine environment by ensuring sustainable fishing practises are used and maintaining an emergency tug of the west Wales coast.
- Reduce dramatically the use of pesticides and introduce measures such as 'buffer zones' around sprayed fields to protect humans as well as wildlife.

Taking animal protection seriously

We share the world with other animals and are not entitled to ill-treat or exploit them.

Accordingly we would:

- Phase out all forms of factory farming and enforce strict animal welfare standards, including in organic agriculture.
- We are committed to fighting bovine TB in support of agriculture, which remains the back bone of the Welsh rural economy. We support the DEFRA-backed vaccination programme rather than ineffective badger culls.
- Protect biodiversity and human and animal health. We will always adopt the 'precautionary principle' with regard to any alleged benefits of new technologies such as genetic modification, cloning, xenotransplantation and nanotechnology.

Social Issues and Everyday Life

Housing

Promoting affordability and sustainability.

The Welsh Government has failed on its commitments to address demand and affordability. Our policies are designed to tackle these issues.

We would:

- Resume direct investment in social housing, which would also provide support to the depressed building industry.
- Reform Council Tax by making people in more expensive houses pay more and those in smaller ones less, adding an additional band at the top for the biggest houses.
- Levy 200% Council tax on empty homes and second homes which are unoccupied for most of the year to encourage owners to sell, let or occupy the property, increasing the supply of housing. Levy taxes on owners of disused commercial premises to discourage long-term land-banking and encourage brownfield sites to be put back in to use for new businesses or housing.
- Provide more rights for homeless people, giving local authorities the same duties with regard to single people and childless couples as to families, and ending the practice of declaring people 'intentionally homeless'.
- End the right to buy and introduce the right to rent. People facing severe difficulties with paying their mortgage and facing repossession should have a right to rent their existing home as council housing, analogous but opposite to the Tory 'right to buy'.
- Ensure that tenant associations are truly democratic and that any further stock transfers are moved to cooperative associations.

Education

Promoting free, public learning.

Education is at the heart of strong communities, and enables social and emotional well-being, equality, inclusion and responsibility. Schools need more freedom to frame the curriculum around the needs and interests of the young people in the school.

There should be an emphasis on pupil-centred learning, which caters for different learning styles, interests and needs.

We would:

- Ensure children are able to attend a good local school with admissions policies decided locally and applying to all schools.
- Work to ensure that money allocated for schools is actually passed on by local authorities, increasing the proportion from the current 75% to 90%.
- Move gradually to get class sizes in Wales down to an average of 20 pupils.
- Defend existing smaller schools and create new ones where appropriate. Large secondary schools in particular are alienating.
- In cities primary schools should cater for 100 to 350 pupils and secondary schools for 600 to 1000. In rural areas Primary schools of 30 should be viable in small communities. However, several small schools may need to share resources such as a head teacher, special needs experts and subject experts.
- Utilise the full potential of school buildings for community use. Evening classes, clubs and libraries open year round to make school buildings a central resource to the wider community.
- Provide free school meals for all – with locally sourced or fair-trade and (where possible) organic food, and with a vegetarian option. This will encourage healthy eating, combat obesity, improve concentration and end the stigma associated with free school meals.
- Let teachers teach – give schools and teachers more freedom over the curriculum they teach. Introduce children to renewable technologies at school by ensuring that most schools get the bulk of their energy from on-site renewable sources.
- Where parents choose to educate their children at home this would be supported by Local Authorities, which would work to ensure that all young people have a broad and diverse education of a high quality.
- Ensure every school has a student council with real say in how the school is run, including input into anti-bullying strategy.
- Phase in the abolition of student tuition fees in higher education for Welsh domiciled students.

The Welsh Language

Our policies to develop local, sustainable economies are an essential step towards supporting Welsh-speaking communities. Strong local economies are the key to the future of the Welsh language. Greens want higher standards and variety from Welsh language public broadcasting. However to thrive Welsh also needs to continue to be a language of the workplace, communities and homes.

Where demand is clear, we would call for across-the-board provision of higher-level Welsh language education and proper provision of Welsh-medium courses within further education colleges. There should be free full and part-time intensive Welsh courses with the right to attend without loss of benefits. The education sector should be monitored to ensure that bilingual education provision meets demand.

In the Assembly Greens would advocate:

- Employer funded Welsh training in the state sector where employees need it.
- Support for S4C in light of the vital resource it provides to Welsh speakers and of its contribution to the vibrant media industry in Wales.
- Application of the Welsh Language Act to the private sector, so that companies employing over 150 people in majority-Welsh-speaking areas have to ensure levels of Welsh language support agreed with the Welsh Language Board.
- Provide support to encourage the use of Welsh outside of formal learning environments.
- Require university authorities to prepare detailed plans on all aspects of Welsh-language provision.

Health

Restoring national health.

Compassion in healthcare and the prevention of illness should be at the forefront of our healthcare service. We would:

- Defend Aneurin Bevan's vision for a free and publicly owned NHS, and prevent services being controlled by privately owned companies.
- In Scotland, free social care is provided for the elderly. We would investigate how a similar scheme could be introduced in Wales.
- Decentralise healthcare responsibility to local government, ensure that minimum service levels and national guidelines are provided to prevent a postcode lottery, and oppose further health service centralisation.
- Keep the health service free – maintain free prescriptions, reintroduce free eye tests and NHS dental treatment for all, and ensure NHS chiropody is widely available.
- Oppose a two-tier health service. The quality of your care should not depend on the depth of your pocket.
- Treat patients with dignity. Patients have both rights and responsibilities – they are not customers who can come and go. Their dignity should be recognised, but they should also treat NHS staff with respect.
- Provide the right to an assisted death within a rigorous framework of regulation, and in the context of the availability of the highest level of palliative care.
- Make available on the NHS complementary medicines that are cost-effective and have been shown to work. More NHS dental care rather than the mass fluoridation of drinking water.

Prevention is better than cure ...

... and part of prevention is greater equality

The Green Party believes in a much stronger emphasis on prevention of ill health, by living healthier lives and encouraging greater equality. This shows how, unlike other parties, our policies are woven together into a coherent whole. Better health is not simply a matter of ever-increasing spending on the NHS.

We cannot have an effective preventive approach or a long-term plan for health improvement, unless we encourage healthier eating, more exercise, a lower-stress, slower-living society, a serious reduction in environmental pollutants, and greater access to tranquil countryside. And we recognise the connection between mental and physical well-being.

Making our society more equal will improve our health, without spending a penny extra on the NHS. Life expectancy, infant mortality, low birth-weight and self-rated health are worse in more unequal societies. Mental illness and drug addiction are much more common in more unequal countries. Obesity is less of a problem in more equal societies like Japan and worst in the most unequal ones like the US.

Local Services

The quality of our lives depends a great deal on the quality of our local services.

None of us wants to travel miles to go to school or to the doctor. Services must be accessible. This means they need to be easy and affordable to reach by public transport – and within walking distance in urban areas. It also makes environmental sense to have good local services. Less travel means less carbon.

Services must be easily available to everyone who needs them. The poor and the vulnerable suffer most when they are far away or too expensive, but we are all affected by the undermining of the social fabric and common culture that good public services represent.

The Green Party opposes the trend towards bigger schools, hospitals, councils and prisons, and more centralised surgeries and Post Offices. Many so-called efficiency savings are bought at a high social cost: isolation, inaccessibility, impersonality, remoteness. They also make our communities less able to cope with change.

Communities and services must be on a human scale. Quality local services are much more important than having a phony choice between a number of distant ones. The poor and the vulnerable suffer most when services are far away or too expensive. Good public services support the social fabric of society and we are all affected when they are undermined.

We would:

- Reopen those Post Offices that misguided Government policy has shut down, and develop a sustainable model for their future growth, recognising their importance in communities.
- Encourage a new, local and mutual financial sector, based on trust rather than

greed, and including community banks, credit unions, local exchange systems and local currencies.

- Support local shops through planning policies including business conservation areas, ensuring basic shops are available within walking distance in all urban areas and restricting the power of supermarkets.
- Preserve smaller local schools and libraries, hospitals and other health facilities.
- Ensure that public transport provides access to local facilities.
- Support local markets giving access to local food.

Transport

Reducing car-dependency

Green Party policy aims to reduce the need to travel whilst increasing accessibility to public transport. Ideally most of us should be able to walk to work, to local schools and to local shops. The creation of strong local economies is vital in this regard because it will mean people need to travel less. Greatly increased investment in public transport is also required to ensure accessibility to all, irrespective of age, wealth or disability.

We would:

- Effectively call a halt to new road building and incremental road improvements, with the exception of genuine safety concerns.
- Halt expansion of Cardiff airport or any others.
- Scrap the subsidised north-air link, reinvesting in improved rail and bus services.

Promoting safety and sustainability

Welsh public transport is under-developed and cannot cope with the needs of a future sustainable Wales. There is a deficiency of rail routes within Wales and a need for alternatives to car and air transport. It is unacceptable that it is currently not possible to travel from South to North Wales by rail within the country.

Investing in public transport will have the effect of strengthening communities, promoting a greater appreciation of place, reducing crime, improving the health of the population and reducing traffic fatalities. Greens would call for:

- The creation of a Passenger Transport Authority for Wales to deliver a truly integrated public transport network accessible to all, controlling fares and deciding routes.
- The Traws Cambria bus network attempts to be all things to all people, discouraging long distance use. Local rural bus services need appropriate support in addition to developing a high quality express bus network.

- A new North-South railway link in Wales using existing track beds where possible. We would identify and safeguard a proposed route from development.
- The electrification of Cardiff and Valleys lines into a modern, light rapid transit system. Electrification of Great Western line all the way to West Wales is vital.
- An hourly service between Aberystwyth and Shrewsbury.
- Providing affordable, cheaper local transport that is accessible to those with disabilities by investing in buses and subsidising some routes.
- Further discounted fares on off-peak journeys for those on a low income.
- Supporting free local transport for pensioners.
- Bringing rail services back into public ownership.

To encourage walking and cycling for shorter journeys and improve road safety we would:

- Reduce speed limits (e.g. to 20mph in built-up areas, including villages).
- Make streets safe by making them public spaces again. Plan for mixed-use developments where shops, housing and businesses are closely located and connected by pavements and cycleways.
- Introduce schemes such as Home Zones, Safe Routes to School and pedestrianisation.

Strong Communities

Communities provide support to people and improve quality of life. To improve the safety of our communities we would:

- Give young people better things to do by increasing expenditure on local authority youth services, ensuring universal access to quality facilities for music, art, drama, dance, sports and youth clubs.
- Improve the design of our cities to provide safer streets and public spaces.
- Ensure future developments are integrated with sustainable transport, rather than relying on car-dependency.
- Provide proper funding for Women's Refuges for victims of domestic violence.
- Repair damage done to public amenities and spaces promptly after a crime has occurred.

Young people play an important role in our community and the Green Party has policies which recognise that supporting them will strengthen our communities:

- A Wales-wide Young People's Executive Council scheme will give representatives aged 11–17 (elected by voters aged 11–18) executive control over a small chunk of their local council's budget (£25,000), which will be a designated youth fund.
- The creation of Young People's Centres (YPCs). Dedicated spaces for young people to meet and be creative. The centres would also offer access to information and specialist support for teenagers in difficulty.
- The creation of a national lead body to regulate youth clubs and YPCs.

- Every young person under the age of 18 and in full time education should be entitled to free off-peak bus fares, to encourage public transport habits in young people early on with a view to making this a behaviour for life.

Citizens

As citizens we think of the good of everyone and of the future, and not just what we think is good for ourselves, now. Creating a fair and sustainable society is a job for government at all levels – but it is also a job for us as citizens.

A particular concern for the Green Party is to respect the right of future generations of citizens not to be disadvantaged by damage that this generation does to the environment.

We must also support solidarity between existing generations, between young and old.

Promoting equality, celebrating diversity

The Green Party aims to treat everyone equally and fairly. We will work to ensure respect for everyone whatever their ethnicity, gender, age, religious belief or non-belief, sexual orientation, class, size, disability or other status.

We would:

- Campaign for homophobic, transphobic and racist crimes, and crimes against disabled people, including people with learning difficulties, to be dealt with effectively and on a par with racist crimes.
- Oppose reductions in health promotion work done to prevent sexually transmitted diseases and campaign against cuts to the AIDS/HIV budget.
- Oppose all opt-outs from equality and antidiscrimination laws by religious organisations and remove special treatment allowing faith schools to promote homophobia on the grounds of religion.
- Provide comprehensive training for teachers and educational staff on all diversity and inclusion issues; schools to promote equal opportunities in their anti-bullying procedures and equality issues to be monitored in teaching recruitment.

Among our key policies in other areas of discrimination, we would work to:

- Strengthen existing strategies to tackle violence against women, including domestic violence, rape, sexual abuse and trafficking.
- Ensure that effective action is taken to prevent discrimination against disabled people.
- End stigma against people with mental health problems, including discrimination in employment.

- Work vigorously towards ensuring that all levels of Government are representative of the diversity of the populations for whom they work.